

Introduction:

The Only Thing Most Understand about Money Matters Is That It Does

To be conscious that you are ignorant of the facts is a great step to knowledge.

—*Benjamin Disraeli*

For many people, money concerns are paramount in the list of anxieties that preoccupy their daily thoughts. The primacy that money plays in many peoples' lives is epitomized by the fact that money is the leading issue that couples fight about, with 37 percent of couples putting it on the top of their bickering list, according to a survey by PayPal. Most telling however is the fact that of the marriages that fail, approximately 57 percent cite arguments over money as the major contributing factor, according to a *USA Today* survey.

One of the best reasons to solve your money problems is that doing so can improve your relationships. This does not just refer to a relationship with a significant other, but also to your bonds with parents and friends. Why will your relationships improve? Because when we are stressed about our finances we become preoccupied with our troubles and find it hard to perform on the job or give attention to our loved ones.

A 2006 nationwide Pew Research Center telephone survey revealed that more than one in three Americans said that they have at some point in their lives felt their financial situation was out of control. The stress caused by these worries